

While booting the live CD, I noticed the new splash screen—the Fedora infinity logo. You see the magic of KMS when GDM loads after the initial boot—the transition effect is, in fact, smooth. You understand the point that Fedora developers are trying to make when they say: “The start-up experience needs to be flicker-free, seamless and shiny.”

On the GDM screen, I also noticed what I believe is the new option for logging in using a finger impression, provided you have a fingerprint reader. I don’t, so I couldn’t test this one.

After logging into the desktop, you’re greeted by the excellent Fedora wallpaper—I loved it for the first time since the project’s inception. It has that professional touch that was always missing. Apart from this, things look pretty much the same visually. It’s the same GNOME 2.6 that we already know of from the Ubuntu and Mandriva Spring releases. The icon set, dubbed Fedora, is the plain old customised theme that made its debut with Fedora 7. Whatever happened to the Echo theme?

A change that I noticed is the new volume control tool. This one gets rid of the separate GNOME ALSA mixer and the one offered by PulseAudio, and integrates everything at one place. It makes sense to control all volumes from one location, but the application lacks the amount of mixers present in the ALSA mixer.

What’s quite discouraging to see is the lack of applications on the live CD. OpenOffice.org is missing, and so is a general digital camera/photo manager application like F-Spot. Well, of course, these can be installed from the online repository, but what is it that fills up the 687MB CD that leaves no room for OOo (which is present by default on all other live CD distros)? The Fedora team says it chooses to support a more complete set of languages that takes up the space as compared to others supporting only English (US). Good enough reasoning, but I guess if you choose to use another localisation setting, it’s a smaller download compared to OOo’s size, which most people will anyway need. The provided AbiWord as a replacement word processor is no solution at all.

Installation notes

Well, time to install the distro. The live installer, I gotta admit, is snappy. The only downside: you don’t have a say in the filesystem you’d like to use for your root. Fedora defaults to ext4. We’ve all heard a lot about data loss in this new FS when a computer is not properly shut down or if the OS crashes—a problem also common with XFS. Ext3, that way, has always been a safe bet. The kernel developers have obviously taken note of the complaints and patches to cure this have been included in version 2.6.30. Fedora, however, ships with 2.6.29, but the developers have reportedly backported these patches to its kernel.

I’d say, good job there. However, I have serious issues with giving the user no choice apart from ext4 for his root FS. The reason being, as I’ve been told, live CDs don’t have the ability to change filesystems. Essentially, they transfer a single preformatted image to the disk and write a boot loader on the system at the end of the process. You can, however, choose



Figure 1: Live CD installer reports ext4 is the only option for root partition

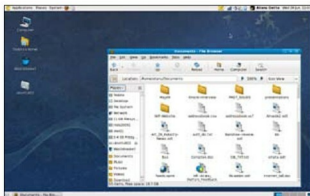


Figure 2: Fedora desktop with the Echo icon theme

your own FS if you’re using the installable DVD. Well, other live systems—viz., Ubuntu, Mandriva, openSUSE—surely let you select your own FS even when you install from live CDs.

Anyway, ext4 it is. The problem again is, it’ll force you to create a separate `/boot` partition of ext3 type, because GRUB still doesn’t have support for ext4. Anyway, enough with the complaints, the installer manages to copy the whole system within 5 to 6 minutes, which I gotta admit is amongst the fastest.

LFY, on the other hand, chose to bundle the DVD for being a more complete package. I got access to the DVD a bit later, which prompted me to fresh install on my assembled desktop PC. Anaconda behaves pretty much the same way, with all the options remaining the same. I still have issues with the partition screen where, by default, it’s set to erase all your partitions. You must select to manually set the partitions from the drop down, unless you’re using a blank hard disk.

While the installation using the live CD was faster compared to the other distros, the installable DVD took a lot of time installing packages. It took more than half-an-hour with the default choice of packages—the only thing that I had added to it were the packages under the virtualisation section. What I’ve noticed with Anaconda over the last few releases is that it starts off installing the packages at good speed, and then gradually slows down irrespective of the package size that it’s installing.